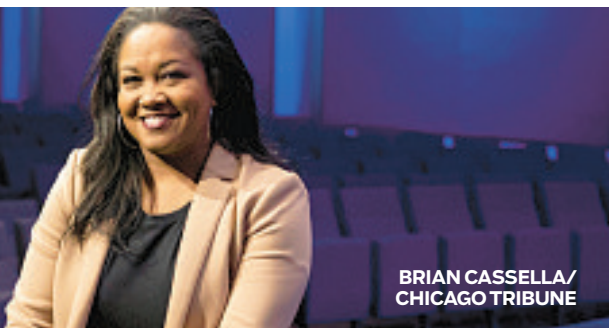


From ‘broom closet’ to an arts hub

South Loop’s FAME Center looks to expand its footprint and its programming to ensure all of Chicago’s kids have access to music education. **Life+Travel**



BRIAN CASSELLA/
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

2025 WINTER ARTS

2024 was a great year for cinema. What now? Early 2025 brings us lots of horror, familiar intellectual properties in recycled scenarios and new takes on old characters. **A+E**

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SUNDAY, JANUARY 5, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



Brooklyn, Illinois, residents Amir Watson, right, and Promise Houston ride bikes on Madison Street in November. Brooklyn is thought to be the first majority-Black town in America to incorporate. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

THE DRIVE TO REVIVE BROOKLYN

By Jonathan Bullington
Chicago Tribune

You may never have heard of Brooklyn, Illinois. You might not be aware it’s one of the country’s first Black settlements, or that it’s thought to be the first majority-Black town in America to incorporate and the oldest such town still in existence today.

You also probably don’t know that it’s dying.

Established in the early 1830s as a refuge for free and enslaved Black people and incorporated in 1873, Brooklyn is nestled on the eastern bank of the Mississippi River across from St. Louis. It was once a key outpost on the Underground Railroad and, later, a welcoming beacon for those fleeing the Jim Crow South.

It was a thriving, close-knit community where, at its peak, more than 2,500 lived under the town motto: “Founded by Chance, Sustained by Courage.”

America’s oldest Black town is in Illinois — and it’s dying. But the fight has begun to save it



Jewell Wells and Prince Wells Jr., left, during a night at The Harlem Club in Brooklyn in the early 1950s with their relatives and friends James Joor, Beatrice Hill, Prentice Hunter and Leatrice Bradley. **WELLS FAMILY PHOTO**

In the last 70 years, though, Brooklyn has spiraled toward extinction. Nearby factories that once employed Brooklynites have long since vanished. Railroad companies whose tracks encircle Brooklyn have, in previous decades, gobbled up swaths of land, displacing residents and shrinking the usable footprint of a village that has about a dozen streets, none with stoplights.

A small but vibrant commercial district disappeared. In its place came strip clubs, adult bookstores and seedy massage parlors that, along with government corruption scandals and a deadly Wild West-style gunfight involving the town’s then-police chief, fueled Brooklyn’s past notoriety as a dangerous den of vice.

Today, Brooklyn’s population has dwindled to around 650. About a third meet the federal definition of impoverished. Roughly 60% of

Turn to Brooklyn, Page 6

State EPA rebuilding under Pritzker

Still, can new blood, money offset Trump’s proposed rollbacks?

By Michael Hawthorne
Chicago Tribune

As the new top environment cop in Illinois, James Jennings knew coming in his job would be challenging no matter who won the presidential election.

The Illinois Environmental Protection Agency is rebuilding under Democratic Gov. JB Pritzker after more than a decade spent shedding inspectors, slowing the policing of air and water pollution and feuding with the state attorney general’s office.

During the past two years alone, the agency added 261 new employees, according to state records. Its budget rose to \$871 million in 2024, nearly double the amount spent in 2020.



But it is unclear if new blood and more money can offset Republican President-elect Donald Trump’s promised rollbacks of federal environmental protections. Trump also vows to dismantle the U.S. EPA, which in recent years led most of the major cases against Illinois polluters.

“Things will be different than how we currently work with the federal government,” Jennings, the new Illinois EPA director, said in a recent interview with the Chicago Tribune. “Our priorities ... are going to be the same.”

Topping Jennings’ agenda is expanding the state’s efforts to slow climate change, taking more aggressive action to protect Illinoisans from toxic forever chemicals, speeding up the removal of brain-damaging lead pipes and addressing environmental justice concerns.

He acknowledged the agency needs to build trust throughout the state — a tough assignment when some believe it is too tough on businesses and others repeatedly document weak enforcement of environmental laws.

“Those of us of a certain age recall the (U.S.) EPA was the

Turn to EPA, Page 10

Americans pay respects to Carter

Mourners in Georgia bid farewell to ‘amazing man,’ 39th president

By Bill Barrow, Jeff Amy and Kate Payne
Associated Press

ATLANTA — Jimmy Carter’s extended public farewell began Saturday in Georgia, with the 39th U.S. president’s flag-draped casket tracing his long arc from the Depression-era South and family farming business to the pinnacle of American political power and

decades as a global humanitarian.

Those chapters shone throughout the opening stanza of a six-day state funeral intended to blend personalized memorials with the ceremonial pomp afforded to former presidents. The longest-lived U.S. executive, Carter died Dec. 29 at the age of 100.

“He was an amazing man. He was held up and propped up and soothed by an amazing woman,” son James Earl “Chip” Carter III, told mourners late Saturday afternoon at the Carter Center, referring to his father and former first lady Rosalynn Carter, who died in

INSIDE: Chicagoland supporters remember Carter’s 1978 visit to the North Shore. **Page 4**

■ Carter visited the area often in the 1970s and 1980s. A look back in photos. **Vintage Chicago Tribune in Opinion, Page 4**

2023. “The two of them together changed the world.”

Grandson Jason Carter, who now chairs the center’s governing board, said, “It’s amazing what you can cram into a hundred years.”

Turn to Carter, Page 4



A military team carries the casket of former President Jimmy Carter into the Jimmy Carter Presidential Library and Museum to lie in repose in Atlanta on Saturday. Carter died Dec. 29 at the age of 100. **BRYNN ANDERSON/AP**



What’s next for the Bears?

Caleb Williams has flashed enough to give the Bears hope. But, boy, did they botch his rookie season, writes the Tribune’s Brad Biggs. Plus, a look at what players want in the team’s next coach. **Chicago Sports**

Signs of trouble ahead for House speaker

While Mike Johnson avoided the dayslong ordeal that his predecessor endured to become speaker, he faces pressure to pass President-elect Donald Trump’s agenda. **Nation & World**

TODAY’S WEATHER



High 24 Low 23

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 16

\$5.75 city and suburbs and elsewhere
177th year No. 5 © Chicago Tribune

